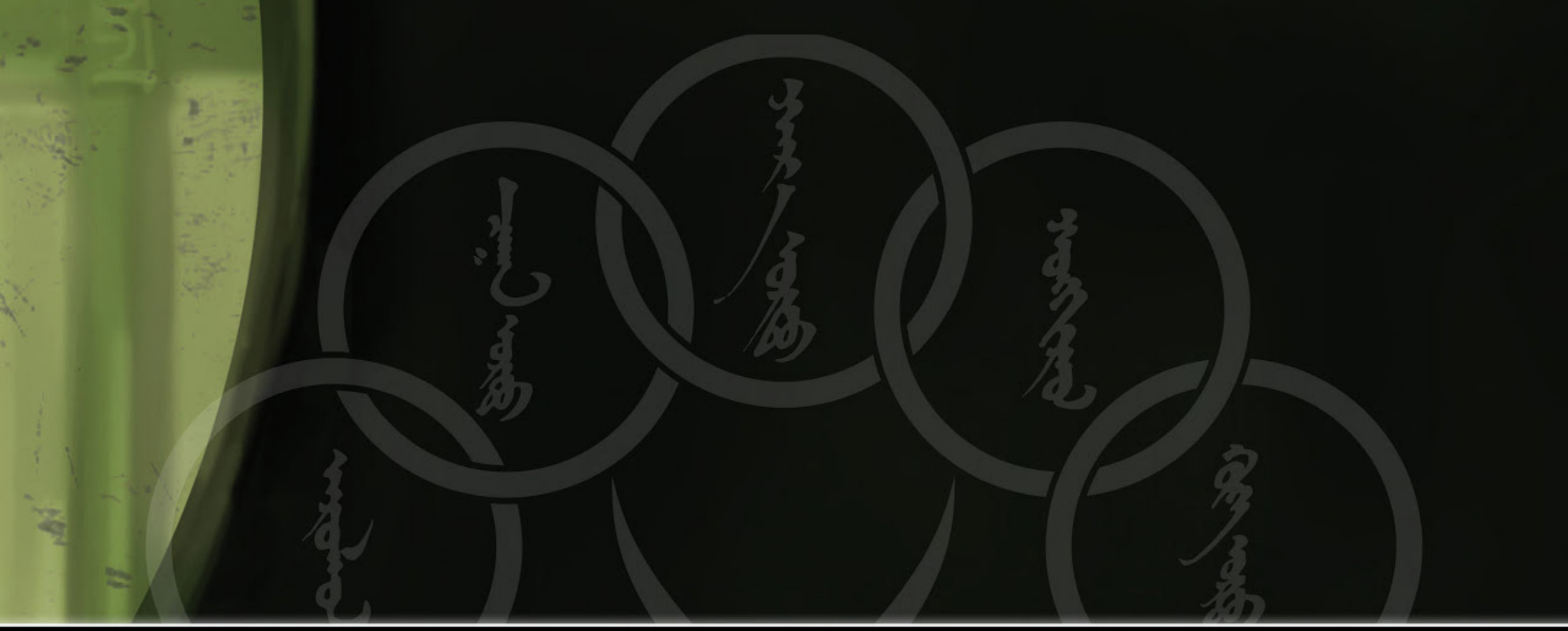


In *Iron Man 3*, Tony Stark faces not one but two heavyweight foes: the charismatic terrorist called the Mandarin and Aldrich Killian—the duplicitous leader of A.I.M., a think tank specializing in several different fields including weapons and technology. A sinister web of intrigue links Killian with the Mandarin, and behind them both lurks a mysterious biochemical process that could reshape all of humanity: Extremis.

The Mandarin, played by Ben Kingsley, is both trickster and fearmonger. He boasts several colorful costumes and ten distinctive rings, one on each finger.

"The symbols on the Mandarin's rings go way back into the comic-book world," Property Master Russell Bobbitt explains. "And in my world, it goes back to *Iron Man 1*, where we made a flag with the ten rings on it. Each symbol represents a different power that the Mandarin has."

Killian, meanwhile, is an ordinary man whose use of Maya Hansen's Extremis process transforms him both mentally and physically. And Killian isn't the only villain powered by Extremis. The process is used to supercharge a small army of extra-powered killers during the course of the film, keeping Tony Stark—and the *Iron Man 3* effects crew—very busy.

"Extremis is fantastical, so we wanted to keep the design of it grounded in reality," Visual Effects Supervisor Chris Townsend says. "We went through a long design-gestation period, creating and trying to find some organic base to the characters. We were trying to keep that tone of gritty realism throughout, so to suddenly have glowing human beings looking real was always going to be a challenge."

Art by Ryan Meinerding.